

A close-up photograph of a young African elephant's head and trunk. The elephant is taking a dust bath, with its trunk curled upwards and a large cloud of pale-brown dust being thrown into the air. The elephant's skin is dark gray and wrinkled, and its tusks are visible at the bottom. The background is a soft, out-of-focus green.

Dust storm

It is more than $\frac{3}{4}$ in (2 cm) thick, but an elephant's tough hide needs just as much care as our own soft skin. This young African elephant is enjoying a dust bath, coating its gray-black skin with pale-brown dry soil, or dust. The dust that settles on its skin absorbs grease and smothers skin parasites, such as ticks, lice, or flies. It also helps to screen the elephant's skin from the harsh rays of the Sun. Elephants also bathe in water and mud, and they rarely pass up the opportunity to scratch their skin on a tree trunk or rock face.